



TIPS & TRICKS



Searching for the repository name locally in Ubuntu

It's difficult to remember the required repository names for various applications in Ubuntu. We can search from the cache generated after an apt-get update for this.

The usage is:

```
apt-cache search [search term(s)]
```

Here's an example:

```
apt-cache search python game binding
```

The above code will search for the terms 'python', 'game' and 'binding' in the repository name and short-description strings, and suggest various repos. You can install the required one by using the 'sudo apt-get install [name]' command.

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Improving the formatting of JSON in GNU/Linux

JSON is a standard format. We can store JSON in a string, but if the string is large then JSON looks very cryptic, and it becomes very difficult to search/edit it. Web browsers/editors provide many add-ons/tools to format JSON better. But doing it from the command line is more efficient, as this can be done quickly and we can automate it as well.

Let us suppose we have a JSON string like what's shown below:

```
'{"DISTRIB_ID": "Ubuntu", "DISTRIB_RELEASE": 15.04, "DISTRIB_CODENAME": "vivid", "DISTRIB_DESCRIPTION": "Ubuntu 15.04"}'
```

...and we want to search/edit something in it but

it looks cryptic. It would be easier if we could format this JSON better. We can do it very easily using the Python interpreter.

Python provides JSON modules that will do the needful. For instance, the following simple command converts the JSON into a readable format:

```
[bash]$ echo '{"DISTRIB_ID": "Ubuntu", "DISTRIB_RELEASE": 15.04, "DISTRIB_CODENAME": "vivid", "DISTRIB_DESCRIPTION": "Ubuntu 15.04"}' | python -m json.tool
```

The output is:

```
{
  "DISTRIB_CODENAME": "vivid",
  "DISTRIB_DESCRIPTION": "Ubuntu 15.04",
  "DISTRIB_ID": "Ubuntu",
  "DISTRIB_RELEASE": 15.04
}
```

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Detecting the operating system of a remote host

Many a time, we need to know details of a remote system. *xprobe2* is a remote active operating system fingerprinting tool that can fetch the details we need.

Let us first install *xprobe2* as follows:

```
#sudo apt-get update
#apt-get install xprobe2
```

After successful installation, run the following command:

```
#sudo xprobe2 <host/ip address>
```